



GROWTH KING

Vellayan Subbiah has disrupted his own businesses and successfully turned around assets. Now he is readying the Murugappa Group for the next phase of growth

BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**

PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

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HE LONG-SLEEVED blue shirt and the Tube Investments of India logo on the pocket sit well with Vellayan Subbiah. His room is spartan and the Mac on the table gets a break, during *BT*'s meeting with him. His mobile is charging in another corner. A replica of the FIFA World Cup trophy finds a pride of place.

It's Chennai, and the summer is just about making its presence felt. No footwear is allowed in the room, and we are seated cross-legged on the floor. Subbiah, a fourth-generation member of the storied southern conglomerate that was founded in 1900,

oversees three of the group's 10 listed companies—Tube Investments of India, CG Power & Industrial Solutions and Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company.

Started by Dewan Bahadur A.M. Murugappa Chettiar with a foray into money lending and banking, by the end of 2025, the Murugappa Group had a turnover of \$11 billion and a net profit of \$1 billion, with a presence across agriculture, engineering and financial services. Subbiah carries that legacy lightly as he leads the diverse businesses under his charge with quiet efficiency and takes them into the next phase of growth.

With forays into areas like semiconductors and clean mobility, Subbiah resonates with what he calls national themes. "It is very important for leading corporates to align with the national agenda. That is what will make things like semiconductors and the new technology spaces successful," he says. Combine that with a comprehensive solution that comes from industry and a lot can happen. "It is a part of the transition that I think is beginning to take place with we are doing today."

Subbiah cites the examples of Japan, South Korea and China, where a similar alignment between corporate and national